

NATURE OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE

Analogy · Symbol · Cognitivism · Non-cognitive Use · Indian Semantic Strategies

01

TWO AXES BEFORE EVERY THEORY

HOW and WHETHER are independent.

HOW

univocal · analogy · symbol · negation · indication

WHETHER

cognitive · mixed · moral-conative · blik · use · meaningless

CONTROL

“God is good” may be analogical in mode and cognitive in intent.

FIREWALL

Meaningfulness, empirical factuality and practical force are different questions.

SEPARATE HOW FROM WHETHER.

02

UNIVOCALITY, EQUIVOCITY AND THE MIDDLE EXITS

Preserve semantic continuity without domesticating transcendence.

UNIVOCITY

Same concept secures inference but risks treating God as a finite instance.

EQUIVOCITY

Radical difference protects transcendence but destroys intelligible reference. Analogy, symbol and negation seek a middle; Scotus qualifies univocity.

REFERENCE NEEDS CONTINUITY AND DIFFERENCE.

03

AQUINAS — ESSENTIAL AND EMINENT PREDICATION

True perfection, inadequate creaturely mode.

RES SIGNIFICATA

Pure perfection—goodness or wisdom—applies truly and is present in God essentially and eminently.

MODUS SIGNIFICANDI

Human language signifies through creaturely modes and remains inadequate. Causal participation grounds ordered likeness; cause-only paraphrase is rejected.

TRUE PERFECTION; INADEQUATE MODE.

04

LATER THOMIST ANALOGY

Use the taxonomy; preserve its historical qualification.

ATTRIBUTION

“Healthy” belongs primarily to animal, derivatively to medicine as cause or complexion as sign. It illustrates ordered use, not the whole divine-goodness doctrine.

PROPORTIONALITY

Goodness belongs to God according to infinite mode and creature according to finite mode. The pair is later Thomist, especially Cajetanian, systematisation.

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USE THE TAXONOMY WITH ITS CAUTION.

05

SCOTUS — SEMANTIC UNIVOCITY

Common concept; different intrinsic modes.

CERTAIN

God is a being.

DOUBTFUL

Finite or infinite?

INFERENCE

The common concept “being” must remain stable.

QUALIFICATION

Univocity is semantic; finite/infinite modes preserve ontology; being is not a genus.

SEMANTIC UNIVOCITY, NOT ONTOLOGICAL SAMENESS.

06

MAIMONIDES — NEGATION AND ACTION

Transcendence gained; vacuity risk retained.

PERMITTED

Negations—God is not ignorant—and attributes of action—merciful from effects.

REJECTED / COST

Positive essential creaturely qualities threaten simplicity. Unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.

NEGATION HAS CONTENT AND A VACUITY COST.

07

TILLICH — SYMBOL AND BEING-ITSELF

A symbol participates; a sign merely points.

SYMBOL

ONTOLOGY

FAILURE / CAUTION

Negations—God is not ignorant—and attributes of action—merciful from effects.

Positive essential creaturely qualities threaten simplicity. Unlimited negation may fail to distinguish God from nothing.

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TILlich — SYMBOL AND BEING-ITSELF

A symbol participates; a sign merely points.

SYMBOL

participates · opens reality/self · transforms · grows · may die

ONTOLOGY

God is being-itself, not highest being. The finite bearer must point beyond itself.

FAILURE / CAUTION

Idolatry and demonic distortion; participation may be vague; non-symbolic being-itself exception was modified and is disputed.

PARTICIPATION EXPLAINS DEPTH; IDOLATRY MARKS FAILURE.

08

RAMSEY AND SPEECH ACTS

Ordinary language is stretched and enacted.

MODEL + QUALIFIER

father/heavenly · cause/first · good/ininitely -> disclosure situation

AUSTIN

locutionary content · illocutionary force · perlocutionary effect

EVANS

self-involving speech commits speaker and constitutes relation; performance can retain assertion.

MODEL, FORCE AND SELF-INVOLVEMENT ARE DISTINCT.

09

SECULAR AND RELIGIOUS USE

Difference of centres, not separate vocabularies.

FUNCTION

describe/predict versus worship/confess/bless/vow

REFERENCE

empirical particulars versus transcendent/non-ostensible

VERIFICATION

determinate procedures versus
contested/experiential/eschatological

COMMITMENT

often detachable versus characteristically self-involving; overlap remains.

FUNCTIONAL DIFFERENCE, SHARED LANGUAGE.

10

AYER AND THE EMPIRICIST PRESSURE

Meaning cannot simply be equated with current testability.

AYER

OBJECTIONS

FUNCTION describe/predict versus worship/confess/bless/vow	REFERENCE empirical particulars versus transcendent/non-ostensible	VERIFICATION determinate procedures versus contested/experiential/eschatological	COMMITMENT often detachable versus characteristically self-involving; overlap remains.
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FUNCTIONAL DIFFERENCE, SHARED LANGUAGE.

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AYER AND THE EMPIRICIST PRESSURE

Meaning cannot simply be equated with current testability.

AYER Synthetic factual meaning requires possible experiential support. "God exists" is called literally meaningless, not false.	OBJECTIONS Criterion self-application and over-restriction. Evidence remains relevant, but non-descriptive meaning and wider warrant must be considered.
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AYER FORCES THE QUESTION; HE DOES NOT SETTLE ALL MEANING.

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FLEW · HARE · MITCHELL · HICK

Four responses to evidential vulnerability.

FLEW Invisible gardener; thousand qualifications may empty content.	HARE Blik: life-shaping and unfalsifiable; practical, not ordinary factual claim.	MITCHELL Partisan: adverse evidence counts; trust is defeasible, not immune.	HICK Celestial city: truth-apt now, possibly verified at journey's end.
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COUNTEREVIDENCE MUST MATTER SOMEWHERE.

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THE COGNITIVE SPECTRUM

Ten positions; never reduce the field to two boxes.

1-2 literal realism · analogical realism	3-4 symbolic realism · eschatological realism	5-6 mixed speech acts · Wittgensteinian use [contested label]	7-8 Braithwaite moral policy · Hare blik	9-10 fictionalism/non-realism · Ayerian elimination
VERDICT Cognitivism faces evidence/reference; non-cognitivism faces reductionism. Mixed realism separates proposition, mode and force.				

LOCATE THE VIEW ON A SPECTRUM.

1-2

literal realism · analogical realism

3-4

symbolic realism · eschatological realism

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BRAITHWAITE

“God is love” -> agapeistic policy + stories. Gain: creed/conduct. Cost: believer intent, secular agape and diverse speech acts.

WITTGENSTEIN / PHILLIPS

Last Judgement is life-orienting, not mere forecast. Grammar/form of life explains use. Phillips rejected simple non-cognitivism;
insulation remains a risk.

PRACTICAL FORCE SUPPLEMENTS; IT NEED NOT REPLACE ASSERTION.

14

ADVAITA — TWO LINGUISTIC LIMITS

Brahman’s ineffability is not māyā’s indeterminability.

BRAHMAN

real (sat), non-objectifiable, ineffable (avācya); words turn back; not “neither real nor unreal”.

MĀYĀ / WORLD

appears yet is sublated -> different from real/unreal (sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa) -> technically anirvacanīya.

MĀYĀ IS ANIRVACANĪYA; BRAHMAN IS SAT AND NON-OBJECTIFIABLE.

15

ADVAITA OPERATIONS AND INDIAN BOUNDARIES

Exact mechanism plus exact school boundary.

NEGATION

neti neti removes limiting predicates.

INDICATION

lakṣaṇā; bhāga-tyāga in tat tvam asi retains consciousness.

OTHER SCHOOLS

Rāmānuja real attributes · Madhyamaka conventional truth · Jain
syādvāda stated respect.

MĪMĀṂSĀ / GRAMMAR

vidhi + mantra + śabda-nityatva; classical sphota belongs
principally to Bharṭṛhari.

INDIAN COMPARISON REQUIRES SCHOOL BOUNDARIES.

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16

SYMBOLISM TOWARD MYSTICISM

Participation can become transparency and self-effacement.

PARTICIPATION

symbol opens depth and draws practitioner in.

INTERIORISATION

Ricoeur's thought and second naïveté; contemplative use.

TRANSCENDENCE

Pseudo-Dionysius: cataphatic to apophatic; symbol becomes transparent.

CULMINATION

Om: A-U-M -> waking/dream/deep sleep -> soundless amātra/turiya.

SYMBOL CAN BECOME TRANSPARENT AND SELF-EFFACING.

17

THE NEGATIVE CASE

Normal route is not necessity or guarantee.

ARREST

idolatry/demonic: bearer claims ultimacy.

CONSTITUTE

Katz: inherited symbols shape experience from the start.

DELETE

Zen and neti neti advance through subtraction.

BYPASS / RETURN

ethics, inquiry, grace are alternatives; mystic returns to symbolic communication.

NORMAL ROUTE DOES NOT MEAN NECESSARY ROUTE.

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SEMANTICS AND RELIGIOUS PLURALISM

Non-literal reference makes pluralism possible, not automatically true.

OPENING

Univocal literalism makes rival claims directly contradictory and pushes toward exclusivism. Analogy, symbol and apophysis permit non-exhaustive modes.

LIMIT

Hick's transcategorical Real inherits vacuity. Advaita nirguṇa/saguṇa and Jain syādvāda add structure. Creator/no-creator and survival/no-survival remain hard contradictions.

ROUTE HARD CONTRADICTIONS; DO NOT HARMONISE THEM.

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FOURTEEN VERIFIED PYQ ROUTES

2018–2025: every printed demand has an exact route.

2018–19

secular/religious · Braithwaite · symbol mediation · whether/how mysticism

2020–21

cognitive content · non-cognitive/Braithwaite · Tillich

2022–23

“God exists” comparison · Wittgenstein · Tillich

2024–25

analogy · 10+10 contradiction/Braithwaite · symbolic? · Advaita anirvacanīyatā

OBEY THE DIRECTIVE AND MARK SPLIT.

EXAMINER-READY ANSWER SPINE

Qualified mixed realism, not literalism or disguised silence.

OPEN

Identify HOW / WHETHER / BOTH; define the exact mechanism.

BUILD

Claim -> named text/thinker/example -> what it proves -> qualification.

TEST

Strongest objection where the mechanism bites; reply without denying residual cost.

TRAPS

cause-only Aquinas · fixed taxonomy · ontological Scotus · simple Phillips label · Brahman=māyā · Mīmāṃsā=sphota.

VERDICT

Intelligible reference + apophatic humility + practical force + critical vulnerability.

MECHANISM → EVIDENCE → OBJECTION → QUALIFIED VERDICT.